



language, and a unique and rich culture. Iceland does not need to use gas, coal, or oil because it is blessed with abundant geothermal energy. This means it has almost no pollution, air quality is

excellent, and food is untainted by chemicals. The country's relationship with the sun is a strange one: for some months during the winter it is entirely absent, while during the summer weeks go by without it ever setting!



THE FISHING INDUSTRY

Iceland has the highest ratio of fishermen of any population. They catch 2.2 million tons (two million tonnes) of fish every year. Cod is the most common saltwater fish but shrimp, redfish, and herring are plentiful too. Freshwater trout and salmon are caught as much for sport and personal consumption as for industry.



HANGING OUT TO DRY

Fish is one of Iceland's staple foods. It is served baked, stewed, or sometimes simply dried and salted. Icelanders are proud of their fish, which swim in uncontaminated waters, and of the purity of their food, which is grown without artificial fertilizers.

The Blue Lagoon is surrounded by 13 ft (4 m) high lava cliffs, which release minerals into the water.



STILL HOT AFTER 30 YEARS

Heimaey island is home to a volcano that erupted very violently in 1973. Today it is still possible to bake bread by burying an unbaked loaf in the volcano's ashes and leaving it for some hours.

THE BLUE LAGOON

A by-product of the Svartsengi geothermal power station is an artificial spa known as the Blue Lagoon. After the hot sea water has been used by the station, it enters a pool where it is mixed with freshwater and cooled to a comfortable 100-110°F (37-39°C). The slightly sulfurous water is only 4 ft (1.2 m) deep, but it is brimming with blue-green algae and white silica mud, which are said to be good for the skin.